

Keeping clean

For most animals, cleaning is part of life's routine. It keeps their bodies in good condition and can get rid of troublesome parasites. Mammals and birds clean their fur and feathers, and even animals as small as houseflies carefully clean their wings. In addition to scraping away dirt, animals often spread out waxes and oils, which act as waterproofing. Cleaning is a personal business, and most animals clean only themselves, or others of their own kind. But the animal world includes species, such as some birds, fish, and shrimp, that make a living from this kind of work. They pick over their "clients," eating anything edible that they find.



Well groomed

Like all cats, a tiger grooms its fur with its tongue and teeth. Its tongue has rough, backward-pointing barbs that work like a comb, pulling out any loose hairs. It removes large objects—such as hooked seeds—with the incisor teeth at the front of its jaws.

Food on the move

In the ocean off Hawaii, this green turtle has attracted a mixed group of surgeonfish. The fish are scraping algae and encrusting animals from its body surface. By cleaning the shell, they help to keep the turtle streamlined. Surgeonfish are only part-time cleaners, but some fish and shrimp get all their food in this way. On coral reefs, they set up feeding stations in prominent places, and their customers often line up to be cleaned.



A surgeonfish's small mouth has a row of narrow teeth that scrapes food off the turtle's body surface